

The Indie SaaS Economy Runs on a Power Law — and the Winners Are Going Anonymous

1,000 Stripe/RevenueCat/Polar-verified startups on TrustMRR reveal how bootstrapped software actually monetizes, who wins, and where the next venture-scale infrastructure play sits.

\$13.5M

Verified MRR tracked across the sample
(~\$161.7M annualized run-rate)

48%

Of all MRR captured by the top 1% of startups
(10 of 1,000)

12.9%

Of listings are anonymous "Stealth" founders
— earning 40x the named-founder median

26.2%

Of startups are actively for sale — a live, data-rich acquisition pipeline

INVESTMENT VERDICT

FUND THE INFRASTRUCTURE, NOT THE AVERAGE STARTUP

Confidence: MEDIUM-HIGH

Bull: Verified-revenue infra & micro-M&A tooling ride a consolidating \$500M+ acquisition market growing 70%+ YoY (Acquire.com, Flippa 2026).

Bear: 70% of tracked startups are flat or declining; category is crowded, top-heavy, and dependent on a handful of outlier winners.

A Fragmented, Fast-Consolidating Market for Proving What a Startup Is Actually Worth

Observation vs. assumption

OBSERVED IN DATA

The verified-revenue micro-SaaS layer

- ◆ 1,000 listed startups already carry \$13.5M in verified MRR — a \$161.7M annualized run-rate on this sample alone
- ◆ 26.2% of listings (262 startups) are actively for sale, with asking prices correlating 0.81 with reported MRR — the market already prices on verified revenue
- ◆ 63.6% settle on Stripe, but RevenueCat (18.9%), Polar, Dodo, Paddle and Lemon Squeezy show a fragmented, multi-rail payments layer with no single source of truth

INFERENCE — SIZING ESTIMATE

TAM / SAM / SOM

TAM

Global bootstrapped / indie software economy + its M&A infrastructure. SaaS is now ~58% of all software M&A; Q3 2025 alone logged 746 SaaS transactions — a record quarter (Software Equity Group, 2025).

SAM

Verified-revenue proof & discovery layer for micro-SaaS deals. Acquire.com: \$500M+ lifetime closed volume, 2,000+ deals, 500K+ users. Flippa: 400K+ weekly active buyers, SaaS listings up 73.5% in 2025.

SOM

What a trust-data infrastructure player can realistically capture near-term: the \$161.7M tracked ARR base plus the 262-deal live for-sale pipeline already flowing through one directory.

Sources: Acquire.com Acquisition Multiples Report (Jan 2026); Flippa 2026 data; Software Equity Group SaaS M&A Report (2025). Figures are third-party market estimates, not derived from the TrustMRR dataset.

Seven Findings That Reframe What "Startup Success" Means in This Data

#	Finding	Evidence	Implication	Conf.
1	Revenue is a power law, not a curve	Top 1% (10 startups) capture 48% of all MRR; top 10% capture 81.8%. Median MRR is \$282 vs. a mean of \$13,472 — a 47x gap.	Build for outlier capture, not the average listing.	High
2	B2B monetizes 5.7x better than B2C	B2B median MRR \$1,036 vs. B2C \$181 (n=255 vs. 401). Within AI alone, B2B AI medians \$1,357 vs. B2C AI \$277.50.	B2B is systematically under-built relative to its economics — 401 builders chase B2C, only 255 chase B2B.	High
3	Anonymity correlates with outperformance	129 "Stealth" listings (12.9% of sample) post a \$7,337 median MRR — 40x the \$185 named-founder median — and generate 28% of total platform MRR.	Serious operators are opting out of personal-brand SaaS.	Medium
4	Most startups are stuck, not growing	Of 893 with growth data: only 30.7% grew MRR in the last 30 days, 42.7% were flat, 26.7% declined.	A growth/retention gap this wide is a product opportunity, not a data artifact.	High
5	AI is the default category, not a differentiator	AI is the #1 primary category (19.7%) and is tag-referenced on 39.2% of all listings — nearly 2 in 5 startups claim AI in some form.	"AI-powered" alone no longer signals differentiation to a diligent buyer.	High
6	The acquisition market prices rationally	Asking price correlates 0.81 with trailing MRR across 262 for-sale listings; median multiple 2.3x, rising to 3.1x–4.0x for AI, Analytics, Marketing and Education.	Verified MRR is already the pricing mechanism — the market wants more of it, faster.	High
7	Traffic and SEO barely explain revenue	Domain Rating correlates only 0.21 with MRR; 82.2% of listings lack visitor data entirely and 15.7% carry a Domain Rating of zero.	Distribution, not SEO authority, is the binding constraint for most builders.	Medium

Founders Behave Like Risk-Managers First, Growth-Chasers Second

These are behavioral inferences drawn from what founders chose to build, price, and disclose — not from direct survey responses.

Trust is the currency

MEDIUM

Every listing exists to prove Stripe/RevenueCat/Polar-verified revenue. The 0.81 correlation between asking price and MRR shows buyers pay for proof, not promises.

Privacy is a competitive tool, not a liability

INFERENCE

12.9% of top performers hide behind "Stealth Company" and out-earn named founders 40x on median MRR — inferred: visibility invites competition, copycats, and platform risk once revenue is real.

Category herding over differentiation

INFERENCE

39.2% of listings tag "AI" — inferred: founders chase visible momentum and fundability signals more than a specific underserved wedge.

Growth apathy after early traction

INFERENCE

42.7% of startups show 0% MRR growth in 30 days — inferred: many operators plateau into "lifestyle maintenance" mode rather than push for compounding growth.

Exit-readiness is normalized, not distress-driven

MEDIUM

26.2% list for sale across every revenue tier, peaking at \$1k–\$10k MRR (35.2%) — inferred: selling a proven small SaaS is now a default career move, not a failure signal.

Switching cost is doing the heavy lifting

HIGH

Active subscriptions correlate 0.906 with MRR — recurring billing lock-in, not one-time sales, is the dominant retention/trust mechanism across the sample.

Five Founder Archetypes Emerge From the Revenue and Behavior Data

#	Segment	Share of Sample	Median MRR	LTV Potential	Acquisition Ease	Strategic Attractiveness
1	Stealth Compounders	12.9% (n=129)	\$7,337	High	Low	Very High
2	B2B AI Operators	7.5% (n=75)	\$1,357	Med-High	Medium	High
3	Visible B2C Creators	40.1% (n=401)	\$181	Low	High	Low
4	Proven Sellers (for-sale, \$1k-10k MRR)	6.9% (n=69*)	~\$2.5k-3k*	High	Medium	High
5	Pre-Revenue Long Tail	19.7% (n=197)	\$0	None yet	Very High	Low

**Segment 4 estimated from the 196 startups in the \$1k–\$10k MRR tier, of which 35.2% are listed for sale (69 startups); median MRR shown is the tier's approximate midpoint, not a direct row-level statistic.*

Ranking rationale: Stealth Compounders and B2B AI Operators combine the highest revenue efficiency with durable, low-churn subscription bases (0.906 subscriber-MRR correlation) — the most attractive segments to build products or funds around.

The Most Valuable Signal in This Data Is Who Chooses to Stay Anonymous

Median MRR: Stealth vs. Named Founders



Why it exists (inference): anonymity likely correlates with operators who are further along — past the personal-brand-building phase and optimizing for defensibility, tax/legal structure, or avoiding copycats once revenue is provable.

Contradiction: SaaS has the weakest exit multiple of any major category

Median resale multiple: SaaS 1.20x — lower than Dev Tools (1.35x), Mobile Apps (2.30x), AI (3.15x), Marketing (3.70x) and Education (3.95x). "SaaS" as a category label is now table-stakes, not a premium signal — differentiation has migrated to vertical AI, marketing, and education use cases.

Weak signal: SEO authority barely predicts revenue

Domain Rating correlates just 0.21 with MRR — versus 0.906 for active subscriptions. 15.7% of listings carry a Domain Rating of zero and still generate revenue. Second-order effect: paid acquisition, community, and platform distribution (App Store, marketplaces, X/Twitter) are doing more work than organic search in this cohort.

Five Structural Gaps the Data Exposes in the Micro-SaaS Economy

#	Opportunity	Evidence	Solution	Revenue Model	Attractiveness	Competition
1	Verified-revenue diligence infrastructure	Buyers already price on trust (0.81 asking-price/MRR correlation) but verification is fragmented across 8+ payment rails.	Acquirers on Flippa/Acquire.com/Empire Flippers; sellers proving revenue	API/embed layer that verifies MRR across Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar, Paddle, Dodo, Lemon Squeezy in one badge	Transaction fee or SaaS subscription to marketplaces & brokers	High
2	B2B-AI-as-a-playbook for solo builders	401 builders chase B2C AI/SaaS at \$181-277 median MRR while 255 B2B builders earn 5.7x more.	Solo/small-team AI builders currently building B2C	Templates, GTM playbooks & tooling that re-route builders from B2C to underserved B2B AI workflows	Course/community + rev-share or SaaS tooling fee	High
3	Micro-SaaS roll-up vehicle at the \$1k-10k tier	On-sale rate peaks at 35.2% in the \$1k-10k MRR tier; median multiple 2.3x vs. 4.1x for broader SaaS M&A (SEG, 2025).	Search-fund style acquirers, family offices, solo-capitalists	Acquire 5-15 proven small SaaS products, centralize ops/growth/support	Consolidated recurring revenue, multiple expansion on resale	High
4	Growth-ops copilot for the stagnant middle	42.7% of startups show 0% 30-day MRR growth; 26.7% are declining — the majority of the market is stuck.	Solo founders past initial launch, pre-plateau or plateaued	AI agent auditing pricing, retention, and channel mix against comparable listings	Usage-based SaaS pricing	Very
5	Anonymous-operator infrastructure	Stealth listings post a 40x median MRR premium over named founders and hold 28% of platform MRR at 12.9% of listings.	High-earning solo founders seeking to stay private	Proxy-LLC formation, virtual banking, faceless brand kits bundled together	Setup + monthly infra fee	Medium

If We Started Tomorrow: The Top 5 Companies We'd Build From This Data

01

Revenue Passport

A verification API that plugs into Flippa, Acquire.com & Empire Flippers to certify MRR across 8+ payment rails in one badge.

TARGET

Solo sellers & buyers in the \$10k-\$1M micro-M&A market

WHY NOW

0.81 asking-price/MRR correlation shows the market already pays for trust — no one owns the cross-rail layer yet

MODEL

Take rate on verified transactions + SaaS fee to marketplaces

MOAT

Data network effects: more verified startups = more valuable buyer graph

MKT SIZE

\$500M+ already transacts through just one marketplace (Acquire.com)

ADVANTAGE

High (moat compounds with data)

RISK

Medium (BD-heavy, multi-platform integrations)

02

B2B-AI Builder Playbook

GTM templates + tooling that redirect solo AI builders from crowded B2C into the 5.7x-better-monetizing B2B lane.

TARGET

Solo/small-team AI builders currently defaulting to consumer products

WHY NOW

255 B2B builders already out-earn 401 B2C builders by 5.7x median MRR — an allocation gap, not a demand gap

MODEL

Community/course + usage-based tooling fee

MOAT

Playbook + tooling bundle is hard to unbundle once workflows are embedded

MKT SIZE

Addressable: 88 B2C-AI builders in this sample alone; thousands more in the wider ecosystem

ADVANTAGE

Medium

RISK

Low (content + light tooling)

03

Micro-SaaS Roll-Up Fund

Acquire 5-15 flat/declining SaaS products in the \$1k-10k MRR tier, centralize growth/support, resell at a higher multiple.

TARGET

LPs seeking non-correlated cash-flowing software assets

WHY NOW

35.2% on-sale rate at this tier, 2.3x median entry multiple vs. 4.1x broader SaaS M&A benchmark (SEG 2025)

MODEL

Cash flow + multiple arbitrage on resale/refinance

MOAT

Operational playbook + capital access, replicable across cohorts

MKT SIZE

196 startups sit in this exact tier in one snapshot alone

ADVANTAGE

Medium-High

RISK

High (capital + ops team required)

04

Stagnation Copilot

AI agent that audits pricing, churn and channel mix against comparable listings for the 69.4% of startups that are flat or declining.

TARGET

Solo founders 6-24 months post-launch, plateaued growth

WHY NOW

42.7% flat + 26.7% declining = more than 2 in 3 startups in the sample

MODEL

Usage-based SaaS subscription

MOAT

Gets smarter with more comparables — proprietary benchmark dataset

MKT SIZE

69.4% of ~1M+ known indie SaaS builders globally (inference)

ADVANTAGE

Medium

RISK

Medium (requires comparable-data flywheel)

05

Faceless Operator Stack

Bundled proxy-LLC formation, virtual banking & anonymous brand kit for high-earning founders who prefer to stay private.

TARGET

Revenue-proven solo founders (the Stealth Compounder segment)

WHY NOW

Stealth founders post a 40x MRR premium and hold 28% of platform MRR at 12.9% of listings

MODEL

Setup fee + monthly infrastructure subscription

MOAT

Regulatory/compliance complexity is the moat once built correctly

MKT SIZE

Niche but high-value: overlaps with the highest-LTV segment identified

ADVANTAGE

Low-Medium

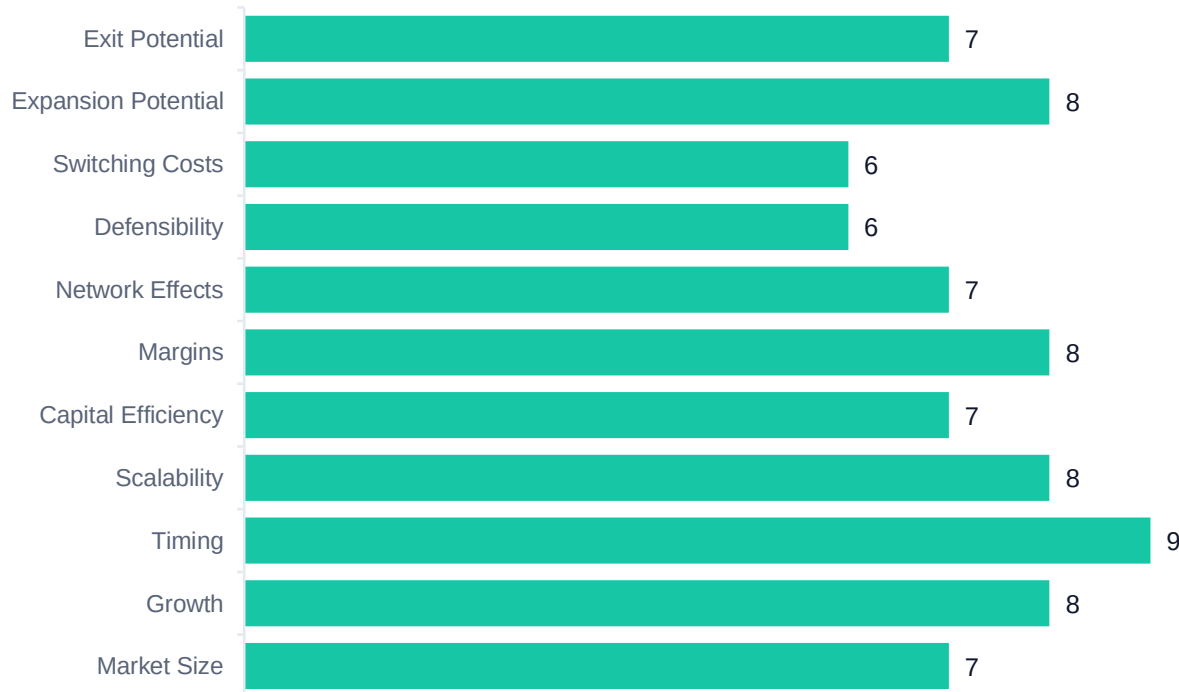
RISK

Medium-High (legal/compliance heavy)

Ranked #1→#5 by combined evidence strength and moat potential. Full rationale in speaker notes.

Scoring the Opportunity Like a Term Sheet: Verified-Revenue Infrastructure

VC Scorecard (0-10) — Revenue Passport / Verification Infrastructure Thesis



WOULD WE INVEST?

Yes — at seed, contingent on distribution

Timing (9/10): SaaS M&A hit a record 746 deals in Q3 2025 alone (SEG); Flippa SaaS listings +73.5% YoY. Volume is here now.

Defensibility (6/10): Data moat builds over time, but incumbents (Acquire.com, Flippa, Empire Flippers) already control 55-65% of marketplace share and could build this natively.

Switching Costs (6/10): Verification is sticky per-listing but founders can re-verify elsewhere; needs an embedded-workflow wedge (escrow, diligence checklists) to lock in.

A 5-Year Path From Verified Data to Owned Infrastructure

0-3 MONTHS Immediate

Ship a single cross-rail MRR verification badge (Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar, Paddle)

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
High	Low	High

KPI: Trust score adoption

3-12 MONTHS Medium-Term

Integrate verification into 1-2 existing marketplaces (Acquire.com, Flippa) as an embedded trust layer

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
High	Medium	Medium

KPI: Verified-listing %

1-5 YEARS Long-Term

Stand up a roll-up vehicle to acquire proven \$1k-10k MRR assets, using proprietary verified-revenue data for underwriting

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
High	High	Medium

KPI: Portfolio IRR

Publish a public benchmark report (like this deck) to seed inbound demand from both sides of the market

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
Medium	Low	High

KPI: Inbound leads

Launch the B2B-AI builder playbook as a lead-gen funnel into the infrastructure product

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
Medium	Low	Medium

KPI: Funnel conversion

Expand into escrow & diligence workflow to raise switching costs and defend against platform-native competition

Impact:	Difficulty:	Confidence:
High	High	Medium

KPI: Net revenue retention

What Could Make This Thesis Wrong

Risk / Limitation	Type	Detail	Mitigation / Read
Survivorship & self-selection bias	INFERENCE	Founders who list on TrustMRR opt into transparency; the true population of failed or hidden startups is systematically under-represented.	<i>Treat all revenue/success rates as an upper bound, not a market average.</i>
Extreme outliers distort means	FACT	One startup ("Stan") alone carries \$3.57M MRR and 101,590 subscriptions — enough to meaningfully skew every mean statistic in this deck.	<i>Every headline figure in this deck uses medians as the primary metric; means are shown only for context.</i>
Growth % is unstable at low bases	FACT	30-day MRR growth ranges from -100% to +12,983%; triple-digit and higher growth rates typically start from a near-zero base.	<i>Growth leaderboards should be read directionally, not as precise magnitudes.</i>
Large gaps in qualitative & traffic data	FACT	82.2% of listings lack visitor data; only 57% have complete positioning fields (value prop, persona, pricing, category).	<i>No CAC, conversion, or funnel-level claims can be made reliably from this dataset.</i>
Geographic conclusions are partial	FACT	24.1% of listings have no country field; country-level revenue comparisons cover roughly 3 in 4 startups only.	<i>Treat country rankings (e.g., US outperformance) as directional, not exhaustive.</i>
Single point-in-time snapshot	FACT	Data is frozen as of 30 Jul 2026 — one cross-section, not a trend line. No causal or longitudinal claims are possible.	<i>Recommend a follow-up snapshot in 2-3 quarters to test whether findings (e.g., stealth premium) persist.</i>
Correlation is not causation	FACT/INFERENCE	Stealth-founder and B2B premiums are correlations; the deck explicitly labels causal explanations as inference throughout.	<i>Any product or fund built on these signals should A/B or pilot-test the underlying causal assumption.</i>
Competitive & regulatory risk to Slide 8/9 ideas	INFERENCE	Marketplaces (Acquire.com, Flippa, Empire Flippers) hold 55-65% share and could build verification natively; anonymous-entity tooling carries KYC/AML exposure.	<i>Any infrastructure play needs a partnership or wedge strategy, not head-on competition.</i>

KEY TAKEAWAYS

If We Could Only Act on Three Insights From This Dataset

01

Revenue is a power law

Top 1% capture 48% of MRR, top 10% capture 81.8%. Build and invest for outlier capture, not the average listing.

02

B2B beats B2C by 5.7x, and it's under-built

401 builders chase B2C at \$181 median MRR while 255 B2B builders earn \$1,036 — an allocation gap investors and builders can exploit.

03

Trust is already the pricing mechanism

0.81 correlation between asking price and verified MRR proves the market pays for proof. Whoever owns cross-rail verification owns the toll booth.

TOP 5 OPPORTUNITIES

1. Verified-revenue diligence infrastructure
2. B2B-AI builder playbook
3. Micro-SaaS roll-up vehicle (\$1k-10k tier)
4. Stagnation-to-growth copilot
5. Faceless / anonymous operator stack

TOP 3 RISKS

1. Survivorship bias — the dataset over-represents transparency-seeking, likely more successful founders
2. 82.2% missing traffic data means no reliable CAC/conversion claims are possible
3. Marketplace incumbents (55-65% share) could build verification natively, eroding the moat

Biggest recommendation: Fund the trust layer, not another listing directory. Build the cross-rail verification API that both marketplaces and founders already implicitly pay for.

Methodology, Sample, and Definitions

Methodology & Sample

- ◆ Source: TrustMRR 1,000-row startup dataset, frozen 30 Jul 2026 (29 fields per record).
- ◆ Revenue fields (MRR, 30d/3m/12m/all-time revenue) are self-reported by founders but verified against a connected payment provider (Stripe, RevenueCat, Polar, Paddle, Dodo Payments, Lemon Squeezy, Superwall, Whop, Creem).
- ◆ Qualitative fields (value proposition, problem solved, pricing model, persona, audience type, category) are founder-submitted and unverified; 43% of listings are missing at least one of these fields.
- ◆ All summary statistics use medians as the primary measure of central tendency given the extreme right-skew of revenue data (mean is 47x the median).
- ◆ Growth percentages are 30-day trailing and can be highly unstable at near-zero revenue bases.

Definitions & Key Figures

MRR

Monthly recurring revenue as reported/verified on the listing at time of snapshot.

Stealth

Listings with the placeholder name "Stealth Company" (n=129), indicating anonymized founder identity.

On-sale rate

Share of listings flagged for sale, by MRR tier: \$0 → 18.8%, \$1-100 → 21.2%, \$100-1k → 24.9%, \$1k-10k → 35.2%, \$10k+ → 30.7%.

Revenue multiple

Asking price ÷ trailing revenue, as listed by the seller (median 2.3x across 262 for-sale listings).

External benchmarks cited

Acquire.com Acquisition Multiples Report (Jan 2026); Flippa 2026 marketplace data; Software Equity Group SaaS M&A Report (2025).